

Maylandia zebra

Zebra mbuna



Location East Africa (Lake Malawi)

Length Up to 4¼ in (12 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

of Africa's large lakes. It has a small mouth with thickened lips, and scrapes algae from rocks. During breeding, the female picks up her eggs in her mouth, and the male then fertilizes them. After the eggs hatch, the female protects the young for about a week.

pale blue-white fins
dark, vertical bars on body



This small, metallic blue fish is one of hundreds of cichlid species that have evolved in the relative isolation

Astronotus ocellatus

Oscar



Location N. South America

Length Up to 16 in (40 cm)
Weight Up to 3¼ lb (1.5 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Not evaluated

Sri Lanka. The oscar, found in South America, has eye-spots—large, orange-ringed black spots at the tail base—that serve to confuse predators. A single spawning contains up to 2,000 eggs. Like most cichlids, this species tends and guards its young.



The cichlid family is a huge group—of perhaps more than 1,600 species—of deep-bodied freshwater fish found mainly in South America, Africa, and

Nemateleotris magnifica

Firefish



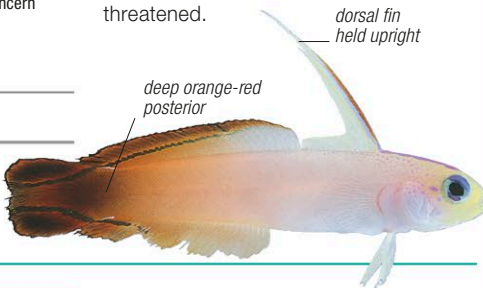
Location Pacific, Indian Ocean

Length Up to 3½ in (8 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

in sand or coral rubble on reefs. Its coloration is distinctive, with a pale head and a body that grades smoothly into a deep orange-red near the tail. Adults hover nervously, alone or in pairs, over their burrows, facing the current while feeding on zooplankton. They quickly dart into the burrows when threatened.

dorsal fin held upright

deep orange-red posterior



This palm-sized tropical fish is one of about 80 related species that construct burrows

Siganus vulpinus

Foxface

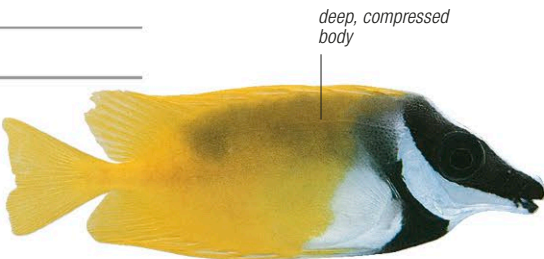


Location Indo-Pacific

Length Up to 9½ in (24 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

and rocks. A single row of flat, spadelike teeth enables it to snip off bits of its food. Its single dorsal fin has 13 sharp spines. The conspicuous black, white, and yellow coloration may serve to warn predators that it has venomous fin spines. Males and females have only one mate at a time.

deep, compressed body



Living close to the bottom in the shallow water above coral reefs, this brightly colored fish feeds primarily on algae that grow over dead corals

Cetoscarus bicolor

Bicolor parrotfishes



Location Indian Ocean, Pacific

Length Up to 35 in (90 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Sequential hermaphrodite
Status Least concern



Parrotfishes get their name from their bright colors and bill-like teeth. As these herbivorous fishes scrape encrusting algae from coral rocks, they also remove and ingest part of the rock. To process this, parrotfishes are also equipped with upper and lower rows of strong, molarlike teeth in the throat. These help in grinding down the rock, transforming it into sand, which is then defecated. Common on coral reefs, parrotfishes are major producers of sand sediments on reefs.

Chaenocephalus aceratus

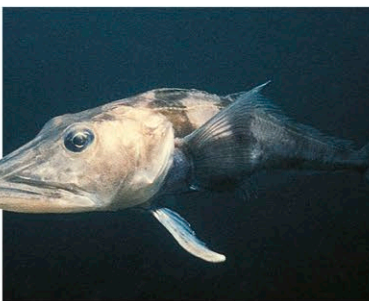
Blackfin icefishes



Location E. South Pacific, W. South Atlantic

Length Up to 28 in (72 cm)
Weight Up to 7¼ lb (3.5 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Not evaluated

The blackfin icefish produces a natural antifreeze, enabling it to survive in the subzero waters of the Antarctic. It lacks red blood cells and this, along with its strong heart, makes circulation easier in cold water, but also gives it a rather pale appearance. It can also absorb oxygen through its scaleless skin. Its large, toothy mouth and flat head led to it being called the crocodile fish by 19th-century whalers.



Dissostichus mawsoni

Antarctic toothfish



Location Antarctic Circle

Length Up to 7¼ ft (2.2 m)
Weight Up to 260 lb (120 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Not evaluated

This bottom-dwelling fish can survive in cold Antarctic waters because it produces special proteins in its tissues and blood that act as an antifreeze. Like many

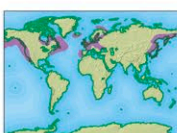
creatures from this region, it grows very slowly, reaching sexual maturity at 8–10 years of age. It may sometimes swim up from the seabed to feed on a range of small fishes, squid, crabs, and prawns. Due to its large size, this fish can be eaten only by a few marine animals, such as sperm whales, killer whales, and elephant seals. The Antarctic toothfish does not have a swim bladder, and achieves neutral buoyancy by having light bones and a high body fat content.

grayish body



Gasterosteus aculeatus

Three-spined stickleback



Location Pacific, Atlantic, Mediterranean, North America, Europe, E. Asia

Length 2 in (5 cm), max 4 in (10 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

This widespread, freshwater and coastal fish is easily identified by the 3 movable spines on its back. Its breeding behavior

is remarkably complex, with the males building underwater nests for the females to enter. When properly stimulated, the females lay a few hundred eggs in the nests for the males to fertilize, and swim out again. The males aerate the eggs and guard the young.

brownish green back

